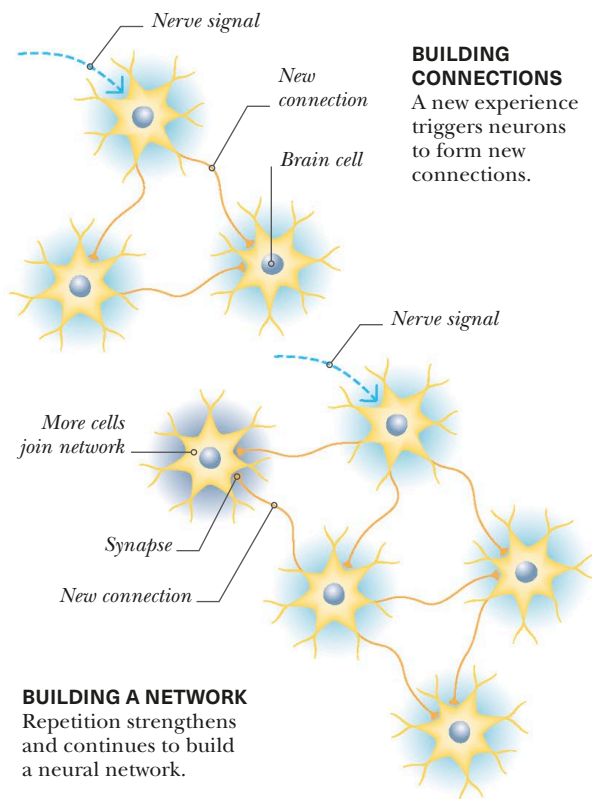




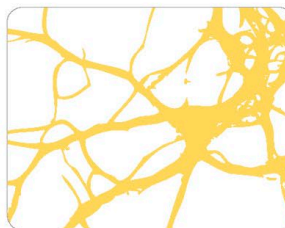
NEURAL PATHWAYS

The brain develops neural connections—and eventually becomes conditioned—based on your choices and experiences. It is said that neurons that fire together, wire together. The more you practice an activity—or a mindset—the more networks are created. With approximately 100 billion neurons, the brain's possible connections are vast. Yoga practices facilitate this process.



CHANGING BRAIN

Neuroplasticity is the ability of your brain to be molded. Not long ago, scientists thought the brain couldn't change after childhood and degraded with age. Now we know that nervous tissue adapts. Like exercise affects your muscles, your brain tissue either develops or atrophies based on stimulation.



UNSTIMULATED BRAIN

Without stimulation, fewer connections are made. The brain tissue looks like a dying tree with sparse branches.



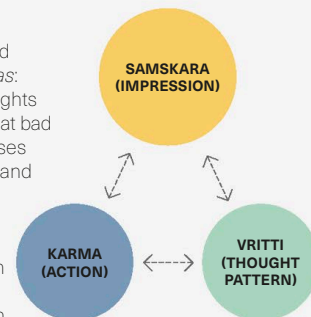
STIMULATED BRAIN

With stimulation, more connections form. The brain tissue looks like a thriving tree with dense branches.



Samskara

Yogis perhaps conceptualized neuroplasticity with *samskaras*: impressions due to past thoughts and actions. Yoga can help beat bad habits or conditioned responses by affecting neural pathways and *samskaras*. This occurs at a synaptic level each time you consciously change your thoughts and actions through awareness and practice. The more you travel that new path, the stronger the connection between the neurons gets.



CYCLIC NATURE OF HABITS



How yoga boosts your brain

There is no neuroplasticity pill. The most effective way to shape your brain is through behavioral changes. Although any yoga practice should encourage neuroplasticity, try the tips here for improved results.

Increase the intensity

Moderate to vigorous physical activity, like from sun salutations, is one of the most effective ways of increasing brain-derived neurotrophic factor. This is a nerve growth factor, which is like a glue that helps to wire in neural connections.

Change your routine

Purposefully and consciously changing your yoga practice routine benefits your mind and your body.

Meditate

Research shows that meditation builds gray matter in your cerebral cortex.

Join a class

The act of moving with a group and following the teacher activates mirror neurons. The mirror neuron system is a recently discovered network of nerves involved in emulation of movement and developing compassion.